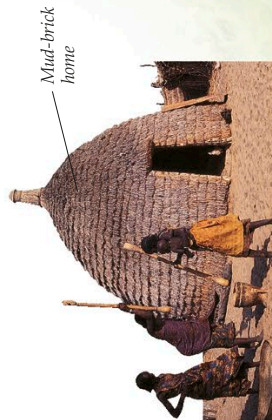




Central Africa

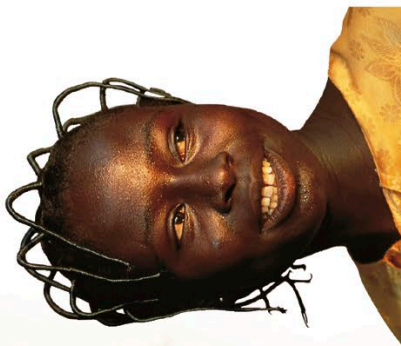
ALL EIGHT COUNTRIES in central Africa were European colonies with a painful history of slavery. Since the 1960s, independence has brought them mixed success. Rich mineral deposits and the discovery of offshore oil have provided income for Cameroon, Congo, and Gabon, while civil war and repressive governments have damaged other countries in the region. These include Chad and the Central African Republic, two of the world's poorest countries. Although the north is mainly arid, Africa's largest tropical rainforest dominates the south, with the powerful Congo River linking the interior with the coast. The tiny, volcanic country of São Tomé and Príncipe lies off the coast of Gabon.

RELIGIOUS BELIEFS
Although Christianity is the main religion here, many people also follow traditional beliefs. These suggest that natural objects, such as mountains and rivers, have a spirit. Masks, like this Bamibuku head, are sometimes used to scare off evil spirits.



VILLAGE LIFE
Most people in rural areas live in villages or small towns. Some grow crops such as cotton or cassava for sale, but many exist by growing food just for their family.

FISHING IN LAKE CHAD
Lake Chad is an important source of food, but it is shrinking at an alarming rate. A shallow lake, it is now only about 6.5–13 ft (2–4 m) deep on average. Its surface area has also reduced, due to droughts and the demand for water to irrigate the land.



PEOPLE OF CHAD
With almost half the country lying in the arid Sahara Desert, more than 70 percent of Chadians work on farmland near the River Chari in the south. Across Chad there are large numbers of ethnic groups, speaking more than 100 languages. Women here live an average of just 51 years and have 4.5 children.

